

LUKE JAMES EVANS

University of Florida, Gainesville, FL
Wildlife Ecology and Conservation

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I am an applied wildlife ecologist whose work sits at the intersection of invasion ecology, population modelling, remote sensing, and decision support. Over the past six years I have built decision support tools that state and federal agencies use every day: invasion risk platforms for the Florida Fish and Wildlife Conservation Commission and the Department of the Interior, and a live evaluation of the National Park Service's twelve-year tegu removal programme in the Everglades. Before that I spent a decade in Malaysian Borneo on human-wildlife conflict, protected area creation, and remote sensing, work that produced a statewide crocodile management plan underpinning a CITES non-detriment finding and helped designate a 400,000 hectare protected area. I have brought in close to \$1 million in funding from four countries, co-supervised two doctoral students to completion, taught on more than 80 field courses, and run workshops that work with agency and NGO staff. My program going forward would have three major themes: invasive and exotic wildlife, human-wildlife conflict and coexistence, and working lands and habitat.

PUBLICATIONS

- Brodrick, P. G.*, **Evans, L. J.***, Martin, R. E., Chadwick, K. D., Vaughn, N. R., Heckler, J. W., Knapp, D. E., Asner, G. P. (**UNDER REVIEW – JOURNAL OF BIOGEOGRAPHY**). Strategic conservation: integrating forest carbon and biodiversity protection. *denotes joint first author. *Manuscript Available*.
- Klinges, D. H., Sofier, L. G., Lenoir, J., Scheffers, B. R., Lembrechts, J. J., **Evans, L. J.**,... Maclean, I. M., D. (**UNDER REVIEW (ROUND 2) – SCIENCE**). Human land use reshapes the pace of climate change experienced by life on Earth. *Manuscript Available*
- **Evans, L. J.**, Baecher, J. A., Klinges, D. H., Scheffers, B. R., (**IN PREP**). An integrative approach for robust invasive species risk assessments. *Draft Available*
- Fredston, A.*, Tingley, M.*, Neate-Clegg M., **Evans, L. J.**,.... Scheffers, B., (2025). Reimagining species on the move across space and time. *Trends in Ecology and Evolution*, 40(7), 629-638.
- **Evans, L. J.**, Baecher, J. A., Scheffers, B. R. (2025). Invasion risk posed by the pet trade. *Frontiers in Ecology and the Environment*, 23(3), e2825.
- Klinges, D. H., Baecher, J. A., Lembrechts, J. J., Maclean, I. M., Lenoir, J., Greiser, C., Ashcroft, M., **Evans, L. J.**, ...& Scheffers, B. R. (2024). Proximal microclimate: Moving beyond spatiotemporal resolution improves ecological predictions. *Global Ecology and Biogeography*, 33(9), e13884.
- Carlson, R. R., **Evans, L. J.**, Foo, S. A., Grady, B. W., Li, J., Seeley, M., ... & Asner, G. P. (2021). Synergistic benefits of conserving land-sea ecosystems. *Global Ecology and Conservation*, 28, e01684.
- Williams, S. et al. (2020). Conservation planning that incorporates regional-scale landscape connectivity. *Conservation Biology*, 34(4), 934-942.
- **Evans, L. J.**, Goossens, B., Davies, A. B., Reynolds, G., Asner, G. P. (2020). Natural and anthropogenic drivers of Bornean elephant movement strategies. *Global Ecology and Conservation*, 22, e00906.
- **Evans, L. J.**, Asner, G. P., & Goossens, B. (2018). Protected area management priorities crucial for the future of Bornean elephants. *Biological Conservation*, 221, 365-373.
- Love, K., Kurz, D. J., Vaughan, I. P., Ke, A., **Evans, L. J.**, & Goossens, B. (2018). Bearded pig (*Sus barbatus*) utilisation of a fragmented forest–oil palm landscape in Sabah, Malaysian Borneo. *Wildlife Research*, 44(8), 603-612.
- Asner, G. P., et al. (2018). Mapped aboveground carbon stocks to advance forest conservation and recovery in Malaysian Borneo. *Biological Conservation*, 217, 289-310.

- Stark, D. J., Vaughan, I. P., **Evans, L. J.**, Kler, H., & Goossens, B. (2018). Combining drones and satellite tracking as an effective tool for informing policy change in riparian habitats: a proboscis monkey case study. *Remote Sensing in Ecology and Conservation*, 4(1), 44-52.
- **Evans, L. J.**, Goossens, B., & Asner, G. P. (2017). Underproductive agriculture aids connectivity in tropical forests. *Forest Ecology and Management*, 401, 159-165.
- **Evans, L. J.**, Davies, A. B., Goossens, B., & Asner, G. P. (2017). Riparian vegetation structure and the hunting behavior of adult estuarine crocodiles. *PloS ONE*, 12(10), e0184804.
- **Evans, L. J.** (2016). Assessing the impacts of habitat fragmentation and subsequent anthropogenic expansion on the behavioural, nesting and population ecology of the estuarine crocodile, *Crocodylus porosus* (Doctoral dissertation, Cardiff University).
- **Evans, L. J.**, Jones, T. H., Pang, K., Saimin, S., & Goossens, B. (2016). Spatial ecology of estuarine crocodile (*Crocodylus porosus*) nesting in a fragmented landscape. *Sensors*, 16(9), 1527
- **Evans, L. J.**, Jones, T. H., Pang, K., Evans, M. N., Saimin, S., & Goossens, B. (2015). Use of drone technology as a tool for behavioral research: a case study of crocodilian nesting. *Herpetological Conservation and Biology*, 10(June), 90–98.
- Miller, J., et al., 2014. Dispatch from the field: ecology of ground-web-building spiders with description of new species (Araneae, Symphytognathidae). *Biodiversity Data Journal*. 2: e1076.
- **Evans, L. J.**, Goossens, B. (2011). Population ecology of the estuarine crocodile (*Crocodylus porosus*) in the lower Kinabatangan River, Sabah. (Master's Thesis, Cardiff University)

*in prep and under review manuscripts relevant to the position have been included for context

EMPLOYMENT

July 2025 – Present

Assistant Scientist – University of Florida
Wildlife Ecology and Conservation

Lead the National Park Service (NPS) evaluation of twelve years of Argentine black and white tegu removal in the Everglades, delivered as a live application that programme managers use to track catch rates, recruitment, and population trend. Co-principal investigator on the \$259,000 NPS award supporting the work. Maintain and extend the invasion risk platforms used daily by the Florida Fish and Wildlife Conservation Commission, including the 2025 climate adaptation module, and serve as the point of contact between agency staff and the tools. Provided here is a dummy data version of the NPS tool, shared with permission, that will allow the search committee to see a product in action (<https://tegu-demo-vt.lukeevansecology.com/>).

Jan 2024 – June 2025

Postdoctoral Researcher – University of Florida
Florida Cooperative Fish and Wildlife Research Unit & Wildlife Ecology and Conservation
PIs – Dr. Conor McGowan & Prof Ben Baiser

I completed a number of projects that spanned a wide variety of topics. Topics included a population model for American crocodiles that examined the impacts of translocating problem crocodiles and the long-term viability of these practises. Creating a prioritization framework that examined candidate beaches for closure to protect nesting shorebird communities. Balancing economics, leisure, and breeding success to provide agencies with the ability to make decisions around future beach closures. Finally, utilizing NEON data to determine that invasive plants represent the greatest challenge when assessing biodiversity throughout the USA.

Jan 2020 – Dec 2023

Postdoctoral Researcher - University of Florida
Wildlife Ecology and Conservation
PIs – Dr. Brett Scheffers & Dr. Christina Romagosa

Quantified the invasion risk posed by the exotic pet trade and turned the results into the statewide invasion risk platform implemented by the Florida Fish and Wildlife Conservation Commission in 2023, which staff use to triage new reports. Modelled climate futures for current and potential invasive species across the Southeast for the Southeast Climate Adaptation Science Center and co-organised its 2022 two-day workshop, in which 25 agency and NGO participants analysed their own data through an interactive application. Published the pet trade risk work in *Frontiers in Ecology and the Environment*. Built decision support for federal invasion science partners within the Cooperative Unit model. Co-developed the Everglades restoration invasion screening tool for the Department of the Interior's Office of Everglades Restoration Initiatives, implemented in 2024, and co-organised the 60-participant University of Florida expert elicitation workshop that supplied one of its data streams. Developed the analytical framework for the tegu removal evaluation that became the 2025 National Park Service award, with agency staff involved in design from the outset.

Jan 2019 – Dec 2020

Postdoctoral Researcher - Arizona State University

Center for Global Discovery and Conservation Science

PI – Dr. Greg Asner

Utilizing different types of remote sensing data to understand the effects of human-mediated change on tropical and sub-tropical ecosystems. This takes the form of impacts on floral and faunal biodiversity, spatial ecology, and population dynamics. Most recently working at the intersection of forest carbon and regional biodiversity.

2017 – Jan 2019

Postdoctoral Researcher – Stanford University - Carnegie Institution for Science

Department of Global Ecology

PI – Dr. Greg Asner

Pairing animal movement and occupancy with remote sensing datasets. Utilizing high-resolution habitat data such as LiDAR imagery to understand and conserve endangered species, throughout Sabah. Working under a Rainforest Trust project charged with the creation of a new 400k hectare protected area within the State. Field work included ground validation of remote sensing datasets across different habitats.

2018 – Jan 2019

Technical Manager, Research and Conservation, Malaysia

Danau Girang Field Centre / Sabah Wildlife Department

Provide technical assistance and project supervision to students and staff of the Danau Girang Field Centre. This includes supervision of two PhD students and general assistance on handling of remote sensing data. In addition, this position included providing statistical assistance on a range of projects. Served in advisory capacity to the Sabah Wildlife Department on a range of topics.

2016 – 2018

Crocodile Conservation Manager, Malaysia

Danau Girang Field Centre / Sabah Wildlife Department

Working at the interface between NGO and governmental conservation strategy. Overseeing state-wide surveys of estuarine crocodiles in Sabah. The project assessed populations within Sabah's major river systems. The assessment determined current population status and trends, key components in the identification of non-detriment findings, under CITES.

EDUCATION

2012 – 2016 - Cardiff School of Biosciences, Cardiff University, UK.

Doctor of Philosophy (Ph.D)

Supervisors – Prof. Benoit Goossens; Dr. Hefin Jones

Examining the effects of human-crocodile conflict. Focusing on satellite tracking, and population genetics, in Sabah, Malaysian Borneo.

2010 – 2011 - Cardiff School of Biosciences, Cardiff University, UK.

Master of Research (MRes)

Supervisor – Prof. Benoit Goossens

Masters-level research across the spectrum of biosciences (molecular biosciences, neuroscience, biomedicine, and organisms and environment).

Research project included the examining of population dynamics and habitat partitioning of crocodile size classes in Sabah, Malaysia.

2007 – 2010 - Cardiff School of Biosciences, Cardiff University, UK.

BSc Biology

A range of field and lab skills across 3 years.

RESEARCH INTERESTS

- Invasion Science
- Remote Sensing
- Human Wildlife Conflict
- Field work
- Science-policy interface
- Conservation Biology
- Decision Support
- Solutions-Based Science

EXTENSION AND OUTREACH

My extension is delivered as tools, workshops, and management plans that agencies, landowners, and communities use, rather than as reports. The record below covers that work; peer-reviewed publications follow.

DECISION SUPPORT TOOLS AND WHITE PAPERS

- Evans, L. J. Romagosa, C. R. COMPLETION JUNE 2027. Tegu removal program evaluation. Nation Park Service (NPS). **IN PROGRESS** (<https://tegu-demo-vt.lukeevansecology.com/>)
- Evans, L. J., Romagosa, C. R., 2025. Climate adaptation considerations in invasion risk development. Invasion risk decision support tool. Florida Fish and Wildlife Conservation Commission (FWC). **IMPLEMENTED.**
- Evans, L. J., Romagosa, C. R., 2023. Invasion risk decision support tool. Florida Fish and Wildlife Conservation Commission (FWC). **IMPLEMENTED.**
- Figueroa, A. Evans, L. J., Daniel, W., Romagosa, C. R. 2024. Everglades restoration invasion support tool. Office of Everglades Restoration (OERI) – Department of the Interior. **IMPLEMENTED.**
- Evans L. J. Baecher A. Cullen, J., Scheffers, B. R., 2022. Climate futures of current and potential invasives in the Southeast USA. Southeast Climate Adaptation Center (SECASC). **IMPLEMENTED.**

- Evans L. J., Kntayya, S. K., Goossens, B. R. 2021. Statewide crocodile population modeling. Sabah, Malaysia State Government. **IMPLEMENTED.**

WORKSHOPS ORGANIZED AND FACILITATED

March 2024

University of Florida Invasive Species Risk Determination Workshop

I co-organized a one day workshop with over 60 participants. Provided a showcase of in-development risk tools. Additionally, I facilitated collection of calibration data from a diverse pool of stakeholders.

May 2022

Southeast Climate Adaptation Center Invasive Species Workshop

I co-organized a 25 participant workshop over 2-days. The workshop featured interactive app use and real-time data analysis and visualization, allowing participants to see and analyze their data.

STATE MANAGEMENT PLANS - SABAH, MALAYSIA

I have been involved as part of a team that has drafted state-wide action plans for several key endangered species, including:

- Proboscis Monkey – IUCN Red List – Endangered
- Bornean Banteng – IUCN Red List - Endangered
- Clouded Leopard – IUCN Red List – Vulnerable

And led a state action plans for:

- Estuarine crocodile – CITES non-deteriment finding

All of these products were taken from initial planning to being fully gazetted into law.

PUBLISHED BOOKS

- Kaur-Kler, J., **Evans, L. J.**, Goossens, B. (2019). Opogi; a Bornean crocodile. Natural History Publications. Kota Kinabalu, Sabah, Malaysia.

MEDIA OUTREACH AND ENGAGEMENT

I have experience engaging with media outlets in a number of ways, with my work being featured in a number of print and digital platforms.

- Local and international newspapers and online news sources (UK, US, and Mongabay)
- A number of television productions from around the world, including Animal Planet production, The Amazon of the East (<https://amzn.to/2lIXkUz>), and Borneo Jungle Diaries (<http://bit.ly/2OFtO5T>).
- Local outreach, engaging local schools and villages, within Malaysia.

SELECT CONFERENCE PRESENTATIONS

- **Evans, L. J.** 2026. Applied Conservation: From Species to Ecosystems. Wildlife Ecology and Conservation Departmental Seminar.

- **Evans, L. J.**, Steen, D. A., Deem, V. R., Ford, R., McGowan, C. P. 2025. American crocodile (*Crocodylus acutus* population modelling under translocation pressures. Florida Cooperative Fish and Wildlife Research Unit Annual Coordinating Committee Meeting.
- **Evans, L. J.**, Baecher, J. A., Scheffers, B. R., 2024. An integrative approach for robust invasive species risk assessments. UF Invasion Science Center Conference.
- **Evans, L. J.**, Figueroa, A., Romagosa, C. R., 2024. The use of R shiny in the development of risk tools. University of Florida invasive species risk determination workshop. Expert elicitation workshop.
- **Evans, L. J.**, Baecher, J. A., Scheffers, B. R., 2023. Invasion risk posed by the pet trade. Species on the Move Conference.
- **Evans, L. J.**, Baecher, J. A., Scheffers, B. R., 2023. Invasion risk posed by the pet trade. North American Invasive Species Management Association (NAISMA) Conference.
- **Evans, L. J.**, Baecher, J. A., Scheffers, B. R., 2022. Climate adaptation of invasive species. North American Invasive Species Management Association (NAISMA) Conference.
- **Evans, L. J.** & Asner G. P. 2017. LiDAR and its utilization in the maintenance of Bornean elephant populations. Heart of Borneo Conference. Kota Kinabalu, Sabah, Malaysia.
- **Evans, L. J.** & Asner G. P. 2017. LiDAR and its application for biodiversity mapping in Sabah. South East Asia Rainforest Research Partnership. Cambridge, UK.
- **Evans, L. J.**, Jones, H., Pang, K., Evans, M. N., Saimin, S., Goossens, B. 2014. Drone technology, a tool for behavioural research; a case study of crocodilian nesting. Borneo Crocodile Forum. Sibu, Sarawak, Malaysia.
- **Evans, L. J.**, Bolongon, G. G., Hearn, A. J., Ambu, L. N., Goossens, B. 2014. Technological successes in the Lower Kinabatangan Wildlife Sanctuary. Society for Conservation Biology – Asia 2014. Malacca, Malaysia.
- Goossens, B., **Evans, L. J.**, Guharajan, R., Harris, M., Hearn, A., Liaw, L.P., Othman, N., Guerrero-Sanchez, S., Stark, D. 2014. Wildlife responses to habitat fragmentation and degradation in the Kinabatangan landscape. Presented at Workshop on Kinabatangan Biodiversity Conservation. Batu Putih, Sabah, Malaysia.
- Goossens, B., **Evans, L. J.**, Guharajan, R., Harris, M., Hearn, A., Liaw, L.P., Othman, N., Guerrero-Sanchez, S., Stark, D. 2014. Wildlife responses to habitat fragmentation and degradation in the Kinabatangan landscape. Presented at Third Country Training Programme 2014: Integrated Biodiversity and Ecosystem Management Training Course. Sandakan, Sabah, Malaysia.
- Goossens, B., **Evans, L. J.**, Guharajan, R., Harris, M., Hearn, A., Liaw, L.P., Othman, N., Guerrero-Sanchez, S., Stark, D. 2014. Wildlife responses to habitat fragmentation and degradation in the Kinabatangan landscape. Presented at Regional Conference on Protected Area and Biodiversity Management in SEA, Kota Kinabalu, Sabah, Malaysia.
- **Evans, L. J.**, Rampangajouw, M., Dausip, J., Saimin, S., Goossens, B. 2012. Human-crocodile conflict: increasing understanding through satellite tracking, resource management and education. IUCN-SSC Crocodile Specialist Group Meeting. Manila, Philippines.

GRANTS

RESEARCH GRANTS

I have acquired grants of various sizes and from a range of sources, including governmental and NGO. I have acquired grants totalling over USD\$950,000.

National Park Service - Department of Interior (2025) (co-PI)

- USD\$259,376

Florida Fish and Wildlife Conservation Commission (2024) (PI)

- USD\$22,605

US Department of Interior (2023) (co-PI)

- USD\$75,465

Florida Fish and Wildlife Conservation Commission (2022) (co-PI)

- USD\$104,302

Columbus Zoo & Aquarium (2015 & 2016) (co-PI)

- USD\$3,000
- USD\$9,448

Chester Zoo (2012-2016) (co-PI)

- ~USD\$20,000 (GBP 12,000)

IUCN Crocodile Specialist Group (2016) (PI)

- USD\$1,000

Crocodile Population State Survey (2016-2019) (co-PI)

- ~USD\$100,000 (ringgit Malaysia (RM)420,000)

Ocean Park (2016-2020) (Major Collaborator)

- ~USD\$400,000 (HK\$ 3,140,517)

Total = ~USD\$995,000

TEACHING INTERESTS

I am interested in teaching a range of topics but have listed a few particular interests below:

Human-Wildlife Conflict	Quantitative Ecology	Spatial Ecology
Invasion Science	Remote Sensing Ecology	Climate Change
Conservation Biology	Field Techniques	Field Courses (local and international)

TEACHING & MENTORING EXPERIENCE

Doctoral mentoring

Sai Kerisha Kntayya – PhD (2018-2024) - *Landscape Genetics and Habitat Viability of the Estuarine Crocodile (Crocodylus porosus) in Sabah: Conservation Management of an Apex Predator.*

Richard Burger – PhD (2016-2023) - *Morphological Attributes and Difficulties of Surveying the Reticulated Python, Malayopython reticulatus, Within a Fragmented Landscape*

Masters mentoring

Fraser Woodburn MS student (2018-2019) – *Density Dependent Growth Rates in Green Turtles Chelonia mydas at Mantanani, Sabah, Malaysia.*

Timmy Garvey – MRes (Masters of Research) student (2015-16) – *Basking site selection and habitat reutilisation in Crocodylus porosus in a lowland riparian floodplain.*

Michelle Sexauer – MS student (2014-15) - *Anthropogenic disturbances along the Kinabatangan River in Borneo, Malaysia and the distribution and abundance of the saltwater crocodile (Crocodylus porosus).*

Undergraduate mentoring

I advised a range of undergraduate students between 2012 and 2025, providing statistical and field-based supervision.

Kieran Love (2014-2016) – *Bearded pig (Sus barbatus) utilisation of a fragmented forest–oil palm landscape in Sabah, Malaysian Borneo.* Resulted in a publication (**Love et al. 2018**)

SEARCH COMMITTEE EXPERIENCE

Involvement in numerous search committees selecting undergraduates for placement years in Borneo. Involved CV and cover letter reviews and subsequent interviews.

FIELD COURSE TEACHING & FIELD CENTER MANAGEMENT

I have a wide range of experience lecturing over 80 field courses, teaching a variety of topics. I also had a position of pastoral care for a range of students, and visitors at Danau Girang Field Center. I was also instrumental in the teaching of approximately 8-12 field courses per annum, consisting of both undergraduate and graduate students. In addition to university level groups, we also taught a variety of school aged children from around the world, although with a focus on students from Malaysia and Singapore.

Field courses came from a wide variety of countries including (but not limited to)

United States:

University of Miami (Ohio) – Graduate Program

Oregon State University– Undergraduate

Portland State University – Undergraduate

University of La Verne – Undergraduate

United Kingdom:

Cardiff University – Undergraduate

University of South Wales – Undergraduate

Aberystwyth University - Undergraduate

Cornwall College – Undergraduate

China:

University of Hong Kong – Mixture of Undergraduate & Graduate

Netherlands:

Leiden University – Mixture of Undergraduate and Graduate

Germany:

Hannover University – Undergraduate

LABORATORY TEACHING

A range of laboratory-based undergraduate and masters-level teaching experience.

PROFESSIONAL ACTIVITIES

PROFESSIONAL APPOINTMENTS

Regional Vice Chairman of the IUCN-SSC Crocodile Specialist Group (2015-2025)

Coordination of regional crocodile activity. As a member of the steering committee, playing an active role in reviewing grant proposals.

REVIEWER EXPERIENCE:

Global Change Biology
International Journal of Remote Sensing
Nature Climate Change
Frontiers in Ecology and Conservation
Conservation Science & Practice
Environmental Science and Ecology

PNAS
Frontiers in Forests and Global Change
Nature Sustainability
Journal of Herpetology
Journal of Natural History
Peer J